CHILD PROTECTION AND SAFEGUARDING POLICY

"Every child we work with has the right to be safe."

Umoja Youth Impact Hub Community Organization (UYIH)

Narok County, Kenya

Policy Owner: Designated Safeguarding Lead (People & Culture Director)

Accountable Officer: Executive Director

Prepared under UYIH Constitution, Article 17 (By-laws and Policies)

1. Statement of Commitment

Umoja Youth Impact Hub (UYIH) exists to serve the youth through environmental sustainability, community health and social welfare, as set out in our Constitution. We extend that same commitment of unity and care to every child we come into contact with through our work, and in any future programme where our work brings us into contact with children.

UYIH has zero tolerance for the abuse, exploitation or neglect of children in any form, by any person acting on our behalf. Every member of UYIH; office bearers, staff, volunteers and members, shares responsibility for keeping children safe, and every concern raised in good faith will be taken seriously, investigated, and acted upon.

2. Purpose

This policy sets out UYIH's standards, procedures and responsibilities for preventing harm to children and for responding promptly and appropriately when a concern arises. It gives every person working with or on behalf of UYIH a clear, common understanding of what is expected of them, and gives children, families, schools and partners confidence in how UYIH conducts itself.

3. Scope

This policy applies to:

- All UYIH office bearers (Chairperson, Secretary, Treasurer), the Executive Director, and all staff, including the Designated Safeguarding Lead;
- All Full, Associate and Honorary Members of UYIH as defined in the Constitution;
- All volunteers, interns, contractors and any person or partner representative engaging with children on UYIH's behalf;

- Every setting in which UYIH engages with children; and prospectively, any future UYIH programme involving children, since this policy is written to extend beyond Green Futures as UYIH's work grows;
- All forms of contact with children, whether in person, by phone, in writing, or online/via social media, and all photography or imagery of children produced in connection with UYIH's work.

For the purposes of this policy, a “child” is any person under the age of 18 years, in line with the Constitution of Kenya, 2010 and the Children Act, 2022.

4. Legal and Policy Framework

This policy is grounded in, and should be read alongside:

- The Constitution of Kenya, 2010 (Article 53 — rights of the child);
- The Children Act, 2022;
- The Basic Education Act, 2013, and Ministry of Education guidelines on prevention of and response to violence against children in schools;
- The Sexual Offences Act, 2006;
- The Data Protection Act, 2019, in respect of children's personal information and images;
- The UN Convention on the Rights of the Child, ratified by Kenya;
- The UYIH Constitution (September 2025), Article 17, under which this policy is prepared by the Office Bearers/Executive Director for discussion and approval by the general membership.

5. Understanding Abuse and Harm

UYIH representatives should be able to recognize the following broad categories of harm. This is not an exhaustive clinical list; anyone unsure whether something constitutes a concern

should raise it with the Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL) rather than decide for themselves that it does not qualify.

- Physical abuse — any act causing physical harm, including corporal punishment;
- Emotional/psychological abuse — persistent emotional mistreatment, humiliation, or terrorizing a child;
- Sexual abuse — any sexual activity or exploitation involving a child, including online/grooming behaviour;
- Neglect — persistent failure to meet a child's basic physical, emotional or educational needs;
- Exploitation — including child labour and any transactional or coercive relationship that takes advantage of a child's vulnerability;
- Bullying and peer-on-peer abuse — including harassment or intimidation among children themselves during UYIH activities;
- Online/digital harm — inappropriate contact, grooming, or sharing of a child's image or information without consent.

6. Guiding Principles

- The best interests of the child are UYIH's primary consideration in every decision.
- UYIH has zero tolerance for abuse, exploitation or neglect of children by anyone acting on its behalf.
- Every concern is taken seriously, regardless of who raises it or how it is raised.
- Children are treated with respect and, age-appropriately, given a voice in matters that affect them.
- Safeguarding is everyone's responsibility; not only that of the Designated Safeguarding Lead.
- Information is shared on a strict need-to-know basis, except where sharing is necessary to protect a child or required by law.

7. Governance and Accountability

Role	Safeguarding Responsibility
Executive Director	Holds overall accountability for safeguarding across UYIH. Ensures this policy is resourced and implemented. Handles any allegation made against the Designated Safeguarding Lead or another member of senior staff, to avoid conflict of interest.
Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL) — People & Culture Director	Day-to-day owner of this policy. Receives and manages all safeguarding concerns and reports; maintains the confidential safeguarding case log; coordinates induction and refresher training; liaises with external authorities where required; reports (in aggregate, non-identifying form) to the Executive Director and Management Committee.
Deputy Safeguarding Lead	To be appointed by UYIH. Should be independent of day-to-day programme delivery where possible, and act in the DSL's absence or where a concern involves the DSL directly.
Management Committee (Chairperson, Secretary, Treasurer)	Constitutional oversight body per Article 17 of the UYIH Constitution. Reviews and ratifies this policy (and future revisions) for approval by the general membership; receives termly, aggregated safeguarding summaries from the DSL; is the escalation point for any allegation against the Executive Director.
All office bearers, staff, members and volunteers	Responsible for following this policy and the Code of Conduct, and for reporting any safeguarding concern immediately, without investigating it themselves.

8. Safe Recruitment and Vetting

No staff member, volunteer, intern or member may have unsupervised contact with children in a UYIH activity until the following steps are complete:

1. Application with a signed safeguarding declaration, disclosing any prior conduct or offence relevant to working with children;

2. Verified national ID;

3. A valid Certificate of Good Conduct (police clearance) from the Directorate of Criminal Investigations, renewed at least every 3 years while the person remains active with UYIH;

4. A signed acknowledgement of this policy and the Code of Conduct (Annex 1) before any child-facing engagement begins;

5. Completion of the mandatory safeguarding induction briefing (Section 12) before first contact with children.

Records of all checks are kept in a confidential personnel file, with access limited to the DSL and the Executive Director. See Annex 3 for the Safe Recruitment Checklist.

9. Code of Conduct for Anyone Working with Children

General conduct

- Never be alone, unsupervised, with a single child in an isolated setting — wherever possible, at least two adults should be present during any activity involving children.
- Treat all children equally; avoid favouritism, including through gifts or preferential attention to particular children.
- Do not use physical discipline or punishment of any kind. UYIH representatives are not permitted to discipline a child — any behavioural concern is referred to the school's own teaching staff.
- Any physical contact should be appropriate, necessary, and never in a manner that could reasonably be misinterpreted.

Transport

- A child should never be transported alone in a private vehicle by a single UYIH representative. Where transport is unavoidable, the DSL must be informed in advance, and a second adult should be present or the arrangement otherwise made known to the school and a parent/guardian.

Communication

- UYIH representatives do not contact children directly via personal phone numbers or personal social media accounts. All communication relating to a child is channeled through the school administration, a parent/guardian, or the Girl Guide unit's adult leaders, as appropriate.

Photography and imagery of children

1. Written consent from a parent/guardian, or from the school administration acting in that capacity for on-site activities under the Ministry's approval framework, must be obtained before any child is photographed or filmed for use outside UYIH's internal records — including UYIH's social media pages, website, or donor/partner reports.

2. Consent can be withdrawn at any time; where it is, the image is removed from public use as soon as practicable.

3. Images must never be sexualized, humiliating, or depict a child in a state of undress or distress.

4. Public captions and posts must not combine a child's full name with identifying details such as their exact home location, in line with good safeguarding practice; where a school or activity name is used, avoid naming individual children in the same post unless consent explicitly covers this.

5. Photography connected to sensitive subject matter; including any menstrual-health or period-poverty-related activity, requires particular care and DSL sign-off before any public use.

6. Photographs and footage are taken on official UYIH devices wherever possible; where a personal device must be used, images are transferred to secure UYIH storage and deleted from the personal device as soon as possible. Access to the image library is limited to staff authorized for communications purposes.

10. Training and Awareness

Every staff member, volunteer, intern and member engaging with children completes a mandatory safeguarding induction briefing before their first child-facing activity; including before any Green Futures school visit. Refresher training is completed at least annually, or sooner if this policy is materially revised. The DSL maintains training records for all UYIH personnel.

11. Recognizing and Responding to a Concern

Concerns may come to light through something a child says (a disclosure), something observed directly, or something reported by a third party (another child, a teacher, a community member). If a child discloses something to you:

1. Stay calm and listen without showing shock or disbelief.

2. Do not promise the child confidentiality; explain, age-appropriately, that you need to tell someone who can help.

3. Do not investigate or interrogate the child with detailed questions; let them speak in their own words.

4. Reassure the child that they were right to tell you and that it is not their fault.

5. As soon as possible afterwards, write down what was said, in the child's own words, with the date, time and who else was present; do not delay to “be sure” first.

6. Report immediately to the Designated Safeguarding Lead using the Concern/Incident Report Form (Annex 2).

12. Reporting Procedure

Every UYIH representative has a personal duty to report a concern; not to decide whether it is “serious enough,” and not to try to resolve it themselves. The flow below sets out who to report to, and when to escalate externally.

Reporting flow

STEP 1 — Anyone with a concern reports it the same day to the Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL), using the Concern/Incident Report Form (Annex 2).

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If the concern is about the DSL — report directly to the Executive Director instead. If the concern is about the Executive Director — report directly to the Management Committee (Chairperson, or Secretary if the Chairperson is implicated).

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STEP 2 — The DSL (or ED/Management Committee, as applicable) assesses the concern within 24 hours: is a child in immediate danger, is a crime suspected, or is this a lower-level welfare concern?

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STEP 3a — IMMEDIATE DANGER: Call Kenya Police (999/112) or the nearest police station's Gender & Children Protection Desk without delay. Notify the DSL/ED as soon as it is safe to do so.

STEP 3b — SUSPECTED ABUSE/CRIME (not immediately life-threatening): DSL escalates within 24–48 hours to Childline Kenya (116) and/or the Directorate of Children Services / County Children's Officer, and to the Kenya Police Gender & Children Protection Desk as appropriate.

STEP 3c — LOWER-LEVEL WELFARE CONCERN: DSL manages internally, in consultation with the school Head Teacher where the concern arose during a Green Futures activity, and records the outcome.

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STEP 4 — For any concern arising during a Green Futures school activity, the school's Head Teacher and the Narok East Sub-County Education Office are also informed, in parallel with (never instead of) the steps above.

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STEP 5 — DSL records the concern, actions taken and outcome in the confidential safeguarding case log, and follows up on any support the child needs.

Key external contacts

Authority	Contact
Emergency (immediate danger to a child)	Kenya Police: 999 or 112
Childline Kenya (toll-free, 24 hours)	116
State Department for Children Services (national)	+254 20 2729800 · ps@childrenservices.go.ke
Narok County Government helpline	020 268 8929 / 03
Narok East Sub-County Education Office	narokeastscde@gmail.com · Tel: 0721718448

13. Managing Allegations Against Staff, Volunteers or Members

1. Any person against whom an allegation is made stands aside from all child-facing duties immediately while the matter is assessed; this is a precaution, not a judgement of guilt.

2. Allegations are handled by the DSL, except where the DSL is the subject (handled by the Executive Director) or the Executive Director is the subject (handled by the Management Committee), consistent with Section 7.

3. Where a criminal offence is suspected, the matter is referred to the Kenya Police without delay; no internal investigation substitutes for a police investigation of a potential crime.

4. Where the allegation does not meet a criminal threshold but breaches this policy or the Code of Conduct, it is handled as a disciplinary matter under Article 18 of the UYIH Constitution.

5. The outcome of every allegation is recorded confidentially in the safeguarding case log, including where an allegation is not substantiated.

14. Confidentiality and Information Sharing

Information about a safeguarding concern is shared strictly on a need-to-know basis. The exception is where sharing information, even without consent, is necessary to protect a child from harm, or is required by law; in either case, protecting the child takes precedence over confidentiality.

15. Record-Keeping and Data Protection

- All concern and incident reports are stored securely, with access limited to the DSL, Deputy DSL and Executive Director.
- Records are retained in line with the Data Protection Act, 2019 and relevant legal guidance; UYIH should seek specific legal advice on retention periods appropriate to child-protection records.
- Any safeguarding information shared with the Management Committee or external partners for reporting purposes is aggregated and anonymised, never identifying an individual child without a specific, lawful reason to do so.

16. Support for the Child

Following any concern, UYIH will take reasonable steps to ensure the child continues to feel safe and is not further isolated or singled out, and will coordinate with the school administration and, where appropriate, the child's parent/guardian, on any additional psychosocial support the child may need.

17. Non-Retaliation

No one who raises a safeguarding concern in good faith will face any form of retaliation or disadvantage within UYIH, even where the concern is ultimately not substantiated. A deliberately false or malicious report, however, may itself be treated as a disciplinary matter under the Constitution.

18. Breaches and Disciplinary Action

Any breach of this policy or the Code of Conduct is treated as a disciplinary matter under Article 18 of the UYIH Constitution, and may result in suspension or expulsion from membership, termination of a volunteer or staff engagement, and/or referral to the relevant authorities, independent of and in addition to this policy's own procedures.

19. Policy Review

This policy is reviewed at least once a year by the Designated Safeguarding Lead and the Management Committee, and sooner following any significant incident, change in Kenyan law, or material change to UYIH's programmes.

20. Adoption

In line with Article 17 of the UYIH Constitution, this policy has been prepared by the Executive Director and Designated Safeguarding Lead on behalf of the Office Bearers, and is submitted to the Management Committee for review and thereafter to the general membership for discussion and approval at an Annual General Meeting or Special General Meeting. Once approved, it is binding on all members, staff and volunteers, per Article 17(3) of the Constitution.

21. Annexes

- **Annex 1 — Code of Conduct Declaration and Signature Form**
- **Annex 2 — Child Protection Concern / Incident Report Form**
- **Annex 3 — Safe Recruitment Checklist**
- **Annex 4 — Key External Contacts (quick reference)**

Annex 1: Code of Conduct Declaration and Signature Form

I confirm that I have read and understood the UYIH Child Protection and Safeguarding Policy and the Code of Conduct set out in Section 9. I agree to conduct myself in line with this policy at all times when engaging with children on behalf of UYIH, and to report any safeguarding concern immediately to the Designated Safeguarding Lead.

Full Name	_____
Role (staff / volunteer / member / other)	_____
School(s)/Programme(s) engaged with	_____
Signature	_____
Date	_____
Countersigned by (DSL)	_____

Annex 2: Child Protection Concern / Incident Report Form

To be completed by the person who received the disclosure or observed the concern, and submitted to the Designated Safeguarding Lead within 24 hours. Use the child's own words where possible; do not add opinions or assumptions.

Name of person completing this form	_____

Date and time of concern/disclosure	_____
Name of child (if known) and school	_____
What was said or observed (child's own words where possible)	_____ _____ _____
Who else was present	_____
Immediate action taken	_____
Reported to (name/role) and when	_____
DSL assessment and next steps	_____
External authority notified (if any) and when	_____
Outcome / case closed date	_____

Annex 3: Safe Recruitment Checklist

Check	Completed (✓/date)
Signed application with safeguarding declaration	
National ID verified	
Certificate of Good Conduct (police clearance) obtained — valid, and renewal due date noted	

Interview completed, including a safeguarding-specific question	
Code of Conduct declaration signed (Annex 1)	
Safeguarding induction briefing completed	
Records filed in confidential personnel file	

Annex 4: Key External Contacts (quick reference)

Authority	Contact
Emergency (immediate danger to a child)	Kenya Police: 999 or 112
Childline Kenya (toll-free, 24 hours)	116

Narok County Government helpline	020 268 8929 / 03
Narok East Sub-County Education Office	narokeastscde@gmail.com · Tel: 0721718448